

Suit up, Pilot!

The best way to elicit tortured groans from any game reviewer is to throw a World War II game at him. The theme has spawned some of the most ridiculous games we've played, but thankfully, *IL-2 Sturmovik 1946* isn't a product of that heartless factory.

The *IL-2* flight simulator series has been around for five years now, and this edition is effectively a round-up of the game and its expansion packs through the years, plus three new ones—*PE-2*, *Sturmoviks over Manchuria* and *46*. The missions and campaigns give some long-overdue attention to the Axis side of WWII as well, even letting you bomb Pearl Harbour! All this adds up to a total of more than 300 different aircraft (and you can fly around 200 of these), so expect to be kept busy for a long time.

Like all worthy flight sims, you can't just jump into the game without familiarising yourself with the long list of flight controls and training missions. Gameplay is as beginner-friendly as these games can get—you can tweak the level of realism you get, though it's fairly tough even at the easiest level. At its most realistic, *IL-2* is pure torture, and will only appeal to hardcore fans of the genre. One nifty feature you'll need when you're starting out is the time-stretching feature, which lets you slow down the game to a quarter of its normal speed—excellent when you're learning combat. Low-altitude dog-fights are extremely challenging, and can be a thrill as you battle it out while trying to keep your wings from hitting treetops. The variety of aircraft at your disposal is mind-boggling, and each has its own perfectly-crafted eccentricities.

The game's graphics look dated—they haven't been updated much since 2001—but the developers' attention to detail is marvellous. Textures degenerate according to the punishment they take (including getting blackened by engine exhaust!), and each plane's cockpit is a near-perfect replica of the real thing, as explained in the 450-page aircraft guide that comes with the game.

IL-2 Sturmovik 1946 is an important milestone in the series, and because it comes loaded with the entire set, you don't need to buy any of the previous lot. Invest in this game if you want something that lets you start out with flight simulators at a comparatively easy level, and adds realism to the gameplay as you get better. If you're a hardcore flight-sim fan, it's a crime to miss this one.

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Rating: 8/10

Developer: Maddox Games, Publisher: Ubisoft

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Price: To Be Announced

Minimum System Requirements: Pentium III 1 GHz, 512 MB RAM, 64MB Graphics Card

